

AP Seminar: The Complete Exam Guide

The two performance tasks and the end-of-course exam explained, the QUEST framework, an argument-analysis playbook, and 10 hard practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.



3 parts

2 performance tasks
+ 1 written exam

55%

of your score comes
from the year's tasks

2 hrs

end-of-course exam
in Bluebook

83–88%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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01 THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Two projects plus an exam

AP Seminar is the first course in the AP Capstone program. Your AP score (1–5) combines a team project, an individual research-based essay and presentation, and a two-hour end-of-course exam.

20%

Team project & prese...

35%

Individual research essay & presentation

45%

End-of-course exam

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
PT 1 • Team project & presentation	20% of score	Individual research report (1,200 words , scored by College Board) and a team multimedia presentation and defense (8–10 minutes , scored by your teacher).
PT 2 • Individual research-based essay & presentation	35% of score	Written argument (2,000 words , scored by College Board) based on stimulus texts, a presentation (6–8 minutes) and an oral defense (2 questions), both scored by your teacher.
End-of-course exam	45% of score 2 hours	3 short-answer questions analyzing an argument in one source, and 1 essay synthesizing four sources into your own argument.

DIGITAL SUBMISSION

Tasks go to the AP Digital Portfolio

Your written work for both performance tasks is submitted in the **AP Digital Portfolio** by the spring deadline. The end-of-course exam is taken in Bluebook.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Your work must be your own

College Board checks for plagiarism and requires proper citation. Teachers can teach skills, but they can't give feedback on the specific work you submit.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

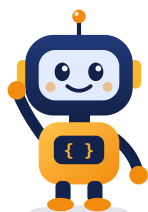
Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 15 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.



Pigo's tip: Seminar rewards **thinking**, not memorized content. Practice asking "what is the argument, and how strong is the evidence?" about everything you read.

02 EXAM DAY The end-of-course exam

A two-hour digital exam in May, worth 45% of your score. There is no multiple choice: you write short answers and an essay based on sources provided.

3

short-answer questions
on one source

1

essay using four
sources

45%

of your total AP score

2 hrs

total exam time

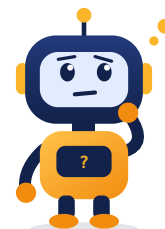
Part A (short answers): identify the author's argument, explain the line of reasoning, and evaluate the evidence.

Part B (essay): build your own argument using at least two of the four sources, with perspectives that connect to a common theme.

Strategies that work on the exam

- Find the claim first: what does the author want readers to believe?
- Trace the line of reasoning: how does each step support the claim?
- Evaluate evidence: is it relevant, credible and sufficient?
- In the essay, argue: don't summarize sources; use them to support your own position.
- Connect perspectives: show how sources agree, disagree or add nuance.
- Budget time: about 30 minutes for Part A, 90 for Part B.

In Part B, sources are **evidence for your argument**, not the argument itself.



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The QUEST framework

Seminar has no fixed content. It builds five big ideas, the QUEST framework, that you apply to any topic.

IDEA

Q

Question & Explore

Be ready to: identify a problem or issue, develop a focused research question, and find relevant, credible sources.

IDEA

U

Understand & Analyze

Be ready to: read critically for purpose; identify claims, reasoning and evidence; evaluate an argument's strength.

IDEA

E

Evaluate Multiple Perspectives

Be ready to: compare perspectives on an issue; explain their assumptions and implications; evaluate competing arguments.

IDEA

S

Synthesize Ideas

Be ready to: combine evidence from multiple sources into your own argument; reach a reasoned conclusion and propose solutions.

IDEA

T

Team, Transform & Transmit

Be ready to: collaborate in a team; adapt your message for an audience; present and defend your work orally and in writing.

04 DURING THE YEAR The performance tasks

Two research projects completed in class during the year make up 55% of your score.

IRR · 1,200 words

Team presentation

IWA · 2,000 words

IMP + defense

PT 1 = 20% · PT 2 = 35%

IRR

Individual Research Report

PT 1 · 1,200 words

Research one lens or perspective on your team's problem, evaluate your sources, and explain how your research contributes to the team's understanding.

Explain why each source is credible, not just what it says.

TMP

Team Multimedia Presentation

PT 1 · 8–10 min + defense

Your team proposes a solution that brings together members' perspectives, presents it, and answers questions.

Show how each member's lens shaped the solution.

IWA

Individual Written Argument

PT 2 · 2,000 words

Using stimulus materials provided by College Board, write your own research question and an evidence-based argument.

Use at least one stimulus text; add strong outside research.

IMP

Presentation & oral defense

PT 2 · 6–8 min + 2 questions

Present your argument and answer two questions from your teacher about your research process and conclusions.

Practice explaining your research choices, not just your findings.

◆ IWA: suggested writing plan

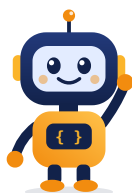
Explore stimulus
week 1

Research
weeks 2–3

Draft
weeks 4–5

Revise & cite
week 6

Your teacher sets the actual schedule; College Board recommends class time for each task.



Teachers and tutors can teach **skills**, but not edit or direct the work you submit.

05

FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

Anatomy of a strong argument

Part A of the exam asks you to analyze an argument. Here is a short practice source and strong answers.

PRACTICE TASK • WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice source (original, for analysis): (1) Cities that ban cars from their downtown streets see more foot traffic in local shops, according to a study of twelve European cities. (2) In the year after the bans, average weekday visitors rose by 18 percent. (3) Critics argue that these results may not apply to American cities, where public transportation is often weaker. (4) Still, the authors conclude that "pedestrian-first design is good for business everywhere." **(a)** Identify the authors' main claim. **(b)** Explain the line of reasoning. **(c)** Evaluate the evidence.

Sample answers

- ① **(a)** The authors claim that "pedestrian-first design is good for business everywhere."
- ② **(b)** They move from a study of twelve European cities, to a measurable result (an 18% rise in weekday visitors), to a general conclusion about all cities.
- ③ **(c)** The evidence is relevant and specific, but **not sufficient** for the word "everywhere": the sample includes only European cities.
- ④ The authors also acknowledge a counterargument about weaker public transport in American cities but don't answer it, which weakens their generalization.

- ① **Quote or precisely paraphrase** the claim.
- ② **Trace the steps** from evidence to conclusion.
- ③ **Judge sufficiency:** does the evidence support the scope of the claim?
- ④ **Notice unanswered counterarguments.**

◆ Five habits for every Seminar task

1

Write a focused, debatable research question.

2

Evaluate each source's credibility and bias.

3

Use sources as evidence, not as the argument.

4

Acknowledge limitations and counterarguments.

5

Cite every source accurately and consistently.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

Just **summarize** the sources! (Nope.)



01 Summary instead of analysis

Explaining what a source says isn't enough. Evaluate its reasoning and evidence.

02 Too broad a question

"How can we fix climate change?" is too big. Narrow to a place, group or solution.

03 Weak sources

Rely on credible, peer-reviewed or expert sources and explain why they are credible.

04 One perspective only

Strong arguments consider multiple perspectives and respond to counterarguments.

05 Missing citations

Uncited ideas count as plagiarism, which can score 0 on a task.

06 Over the word limit

Respect limits: 1,200 words for the IRR and 2,000 for the IWA.

07 Ignoring the stimulus

The IWA must connect to at least one stimulus text provided by College Board.

08 Solutions without evidence

Proposed solutions need support and should address limitations.

09 Reading the presentation

Speak to the audience; slides should support, not replace, your talk.

10 Unprepared oral defense

Expect questions on your research process, not just conclusions.

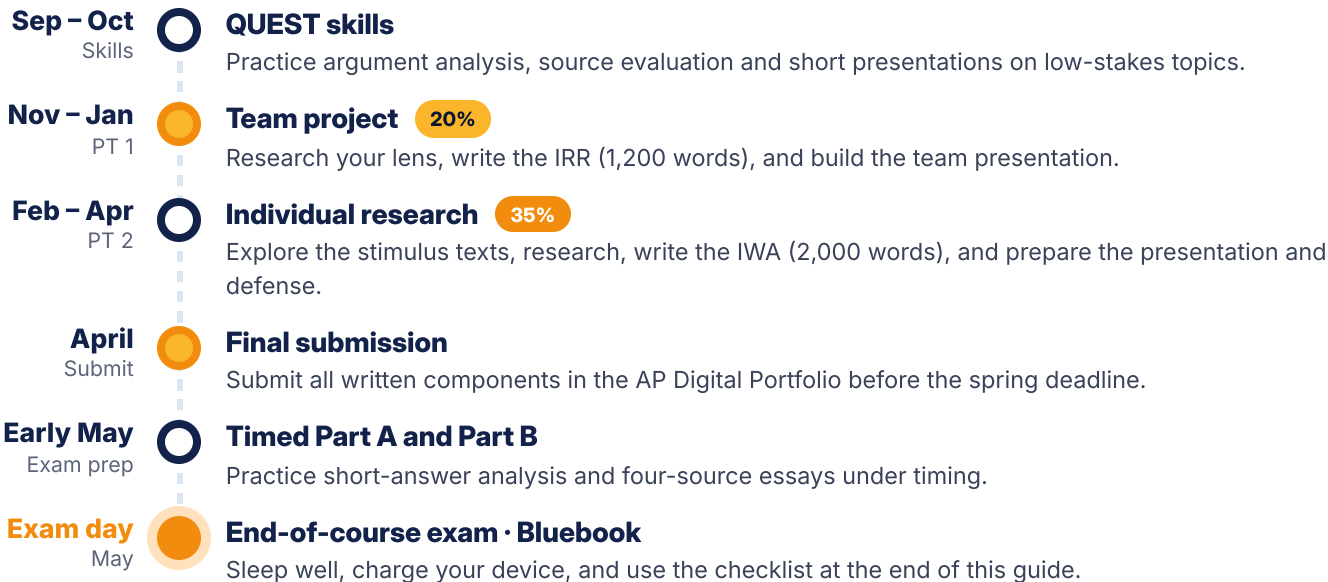
Quick self-check: can you state your current research question in one sentence, and name the strongest counterargument to your position?

07

PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Your teacher sets the task schedule; use it to plan backward from the deadlines.



◆ The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	One timed Part A (3 short answers)	Identify claim, reasoning, evidence
3 weeks out	One timed Part B essay	Use at least two sources
2 weeks out	Full 2-hour practice exam	Finish both parts
Final week	Light review: argument vocabulary, traps list	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF

10 practice questions

Original argument-analysis questions written by ACT SAT GO, in the spirit of the exam's skills (the real exam is written, not multiple choice). Give yourself **15 minutes**, then check page 11.

1 ARGUMENT • CLAIM

Questions 1–5 refer to the source below.

(1) Cities that ban cars from their downtown streets see more foot traffic in local shops, according to a study of twelve European cities. (2) In the year after the bans, average weekday visitors rose by 18 percent. (3) Critics argue that these results may not apply to American cities, where public transportation is often weaker. (4) Still, the authors conclude that "pedestrian-first design is good for business everywhere."

Original passage written by ACT SAT GO for practice

Which sentence states the authors' main claim?

- A Sentence 1
- B Sentence 2
- C Sentence 3
- D Sentence 4

2 ARGUMENT • EVIDENCE

Sentence 2 functions mainly as:

- A a counterargument
- B the authors' conclusion
- C quantitative evidence supporting the claim
- D a definition

3 ARGUMENT • EVALUATION

The biggest weakness in the authors' reasoning is that:

- A they generalize to "everywhere" from a sample of European cities only
- B they use numbers
- C they mention critics
- D they study weekday visitors

4 ARGUMENT • PERSPECTIVE

Sentence 3 introduces:

- A supporting evidence
- B a counterargument about applicability
- C the study's method
- D a definition of foot traffic

5 RESEARCH • NEXT STEP

Which additional evidence would most strengthen the authors' conclusion?

- A A second study of the same twelve cities
- B Quotations from shop owners in Europe
- C Data from car-free zones in American cities with different transit systems
- D A history of city planning

08 TEST YOURSELF (continued)

6 RESEARCH QUESTION

Which is the most effective research question for an IWA?

- A To what extent do school phone bans improve students' in-class attention in U.S. high schools?
- B What is social media?
- C Is social media good or bad?
- D Why do people like phones?

7 SOURCE EVALUATION

Which source is likely the most credible for an argument about vaccine safety?

- A An anonymous blog post
- B A peer-reviewed study in a medical journal
- C A celebrity's social media video
- D An advertisement from a supplement company

8 SYNTHESIS

In a Part B essay, the best way to use sources is to:

- A summarize each source in order
- B quote as much text as possible
- C agree with every source
- D use them as evidence for your own argument and show how their perspectives relate

9 BIAS

A study on the benefits of sugary drinks was funded by a soft-drink company. This most directly raises concern about:

- | | |
|------------------|---------------|
| A potential bias | B sample size |
| C citation style | D word count |

10 REASONING

"Students who eat breakfast earn higher grades, so breakfast causes higher grades." This reasoning confuses:

- A a definition with an example
- B a claim with a counterclaim
- C correlation with causation
- D qualitative with quantitative data



CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	D - Sentence 4	The authors conclude that "pedestrian-first design is good for business everywhere." Sentences 1–2 are evidence; 3 is a counterargument.
2	C	The 18% rise in weekday visitors is quantitative evidence supporting the claim.
3	A	Evidence from twelve European cities doesn't justify "everywhere": the generalization exceeds the evidence.
4	B	Sentence 3 raises a counterargument: results may not apply where public transport is weaker.
5	C	Data from American cities directly addresses the unanswered counterargument and broadens the sample.
6	A	It is focused (place, group, measurable outcome) and debatable, using "to what extent".
7	B	Peer-reviewed studies are vetted by experts, making them more credible than the other options.
8	D	Synthesis means using sources as evidence and connecting their perspectives, not summarizing them.
9	A	Industry funding creates a potential conflict of interest, which raises concern about bias.
10	C	An association between breakfast and grades doesn't prove breakfast causes them; other factors may explain both.

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Practice finding the claim, reasoning and evidence in one article every day.

10 KNOW THE TARGET How students score

In recent years, about 83–88% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP Seminar, and about 9–10% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

83–88%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

9–10%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ All performance-task components **submitted** in the AP Digital Portfolio
- ☐ Plan your time: about **30 min** for Part A and **90 min** for Part B
- ☐ For Part B, use **at least two** of the four sources
- ☐ Practice typing a full four-source essay in 90 minutes

On the exam and in your tasks: identify claims, reasoning and evidence precisely, evaluate credibility and sufficiency, use sources as evidence for your own argument, and respond to counterarguments.



ACT SAT GO • 1-ON-1 AP TUTORING

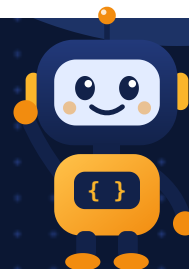
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Book a free diagnostic lesson. We'll find your weakest units, review your practice responses, and give you a week-by-week plan to exam day in May.

Book a free diagnostic lesson →



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